

DTF for Cotton: 1-Page Cheat Sheet

● SUB CAMP 2026 · NINJA TRANSFERS

Tape this next to your heat press. Same press, new fabric.

Settings by fabric

Preheat first. Pressing pillow under seams or multi-layer goods. Silicone cover = silicone upper platen pad (runs hotter than parchment or teflon).

FABRIC	NO SILICONE COVER	WITH SILICONE COVER
Cotton (light or dark)	310°F · 15s · Med-High	330°F · 15s · Med-High
50/50 blends, triblends	300°F · 12s · Med	320°F · 12s · Med
Polyester, jerseys, mesh	290°F · 12s · Med + pillow	310°F · 12s · Med + pillow
Denim, canvas, heavy	320°F · 15s · Firm	340°F · 15s · Firm
Hoodies (multi-layer)	310°F · 17s · Med-High + pillow	330°F · 17s · Med-High + pillow
Hats / structured	320°F top · 130°F bot · 15s + tape	340°F top · 130°F bot · 15s + tape

Steps

1. (Optional) Pre-press the shirt 3 to 5 seconds to pull moisture out. Helpful on humid days.
2. Lay the garment flat on the press.
3. Place the DTF film design-side up on the garment.
4. Cover with parchment, teflon sheet, or silicone protector.
5. Press using the temp, time, and pressure for your fabric (table above).

The Peel

Wait at least 5 seconds after the press lifts, then peel the film in one smooth motion. Hot peel is fine. The transfer should still be warm.

If any part of the design lifts with the film, lay it back down, give that area a quick second press, then re-peel.

COLD PEEL ONLY

Glitter, gold or silver foil, and glow-in-the-dark are cold peel. Wait until fully cool before peeling those.

The Second Press

DON'T SKIP THIS

The step most crafters skip is the one that matters most for wash durability.

After peeling, cover the design with fresh parchment (or a single layer of T-shirt material) and press again at the **same temp, time, and pressure as your first press**. Improves hand feel, reduces shine, locks in long-term wash performance. Wait 24 hours before the first wash.

When Something Goes Wrong

ISSUE	FIX
Transfer not adhering	Increase pressure first, then re-press for the full press time at your fabric's temp. Pressure matters more than temperature.
Shiny or plastic finish	Do a second press with parchment or a silicone pad on top. The cover sheet matters here.
Halo or outline visible	Use a cover sheet and check that pressure is even. For seams, zippers, or buttons, place a heat press pillow under the garment.
Film lifts when peeling	Lay it back down, press another 5 to 8 seconds, then re-peel in one smooth motion. Yanking the film cracks the print.

What You Can Press Next

Same press, different transfer. Once you nail cotton, none of these are scary.

Hoodies

Fleece

Denim

Tote bags

Hats

Dark cotton

Heavy cotton

Glow

Foil

Glitter

Spangle

UV DTF on hard goods

